

INTRO TO

FUTURES

IN 1
HOUR



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GETTING STARTED

WHAT IS FUTURES?

It is tuning into society's undisclosed motives, aspirations and preferences in order to see and pursue opportunities that might otherwise be unavailable to the imagination.

WHAT TOOLS DO I NEED?

This exercise will teach you the basics of some tools that futurists use to think critically and creatively about the future. You will need this booklet, the provided worksheet and a partner for the next hour. Fill out the worksheet as you each progress to save time and make the activity easier.

GRAB YOUR WORKSHEET

STEP 1

Time: 2 min

Your goal is to imagine alternative futures of (insert topic on your worksheet) in the next 10+ years.

HINT:

You can choose any topic with your partner, but it helps to start with something simple like “ice cream.”

WHO WILL CARE?

STEP 2

Time: 5 min

Discuss and list on your worksheet the main stakeholder groups most involved / impacted in this domain.

Circle the group whose future you are most interested in. From now on your job is to step into the shoes of this group. We will call this group the **Main Stakeholder**.

A _____

B _____

C _____

D _____

E _____

STEP 3

Time: 10 min

Discuss and list on your worksheet as many **critical uncertainties*** as possible including their extremes as it relates to the future of your selected topic across the following STEEP (social, technological, economic, environmental, political) categories.

**A critical uncertainty is a factor that could significantly impact your future one way or the other. It could have a transformative, disruptive or evolutionary impact on that future. For example, for the future of the workplace:*

Uncertainty Name	Extreme A	(vs)	Extreme B
Staffing Resources	Robots		Human

Uncertainty Name	Extreme A	(vs)	Extreme B

WHAT ARE THE SCENARIOS?

STEP 4

Time: 3 min

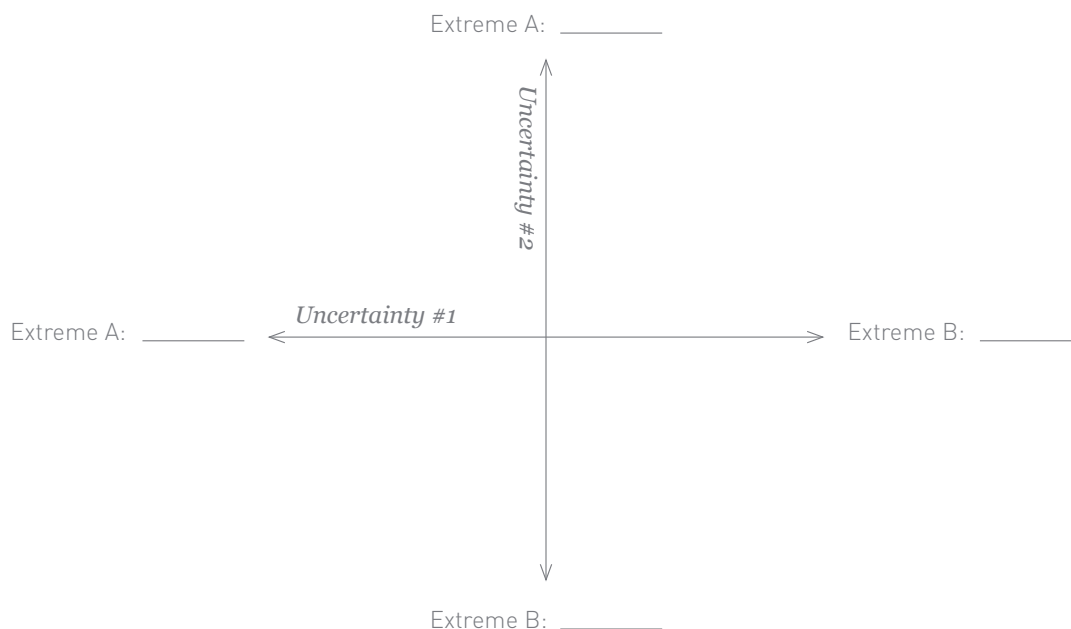
Discuss and pick the **top two critical uncertainties** that could **most** significantly impact your future one way or the other. Write the uncertainties and their corresponding extremes on your worksheet.

STEP 5

Time: 2 min

Each quadrant (area of the square) represents four unique scenarios.

- A) Discuss for a moment what each of these scenarios might mean and which scenario would be **most and least preferred to the Main Stakeholder**.
- B) Mark on your worksheet the most preferred scenario with a 😊 and the least preferred with a ☹.
- C) Assign randomly the 😊 and ☹ scenarios to each player.



WHO'S IN CHARGE?

STEP 6

Time: 3 min

Individually, list on your worksheet all the stakeholders from Step 2 in **decreasing order of agency*** per your assigned scenario.

**The stakeholder listed #1 has the most power/influence/control in your scenario. The stakeholder listed #5 has the least.*

1 _____

2 _____

3 _____

4 _____

5 _____

STEP 7

Time: 5 min

Read the list of universal values below that guide human behavior and identify **what value guides each stakeholder** the most in your scenario. List the selected value next to each stakeholder on your worksheet (choose one value per stakeholder).

- **Power** - having social status, prestige, control or dominance over people / resources
- **Achievement** - personal success through demonstrating competence, having influence
- **Indulgence** - enjoying life, pleasure and self-gratification
- **Novelty** - seeking excitement, variety and challenge in life
- **Self-direction** - independent thought, freedom to be creative and curious
- **Universalism** - understanding and appreciation for the welfare of all people and nature, a world at peace
- **Benevolence** - preservation and enhancement of the welfare of people with whom one is in frequent personal contact, helpful, loyal, honest
- **Tradition** - respect and commitment to the culture and ideas of traditional culture or religion
- **Conformity** - restraint of actions likely to upset or violate others or social norms, self-disciplined
- **Security** - safety, harmony and stability of society, relationships and self

WHAT'S THE STORY?

STEP 8

Time: 5 min

Individually, answer these questions on your worksheet to help describe the **behavior of each stakeholder group** in the same order of agency as you listed in step 6.

1. This stakeholder group maintains or improves its position in this scenario by _____
(describe behavior)
2. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains or improves its position in this scenario by _____
3. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains or improves its position in this scenario by _____
4. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains or improves its position in this scenario by _____
5. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains or improves its position in this scenario by _____

STEP 9

Time: 5 min

You now have a basic description of what takes place in your scenario. Take 1 minute to **name your scenario** on your worksheet. Use two words at most. It can be sarcastic, serious or both. Then share your scenario description with your partner.

Scenario Name: _____

Notes:

WHAT COULD IT LOOK LIKE?

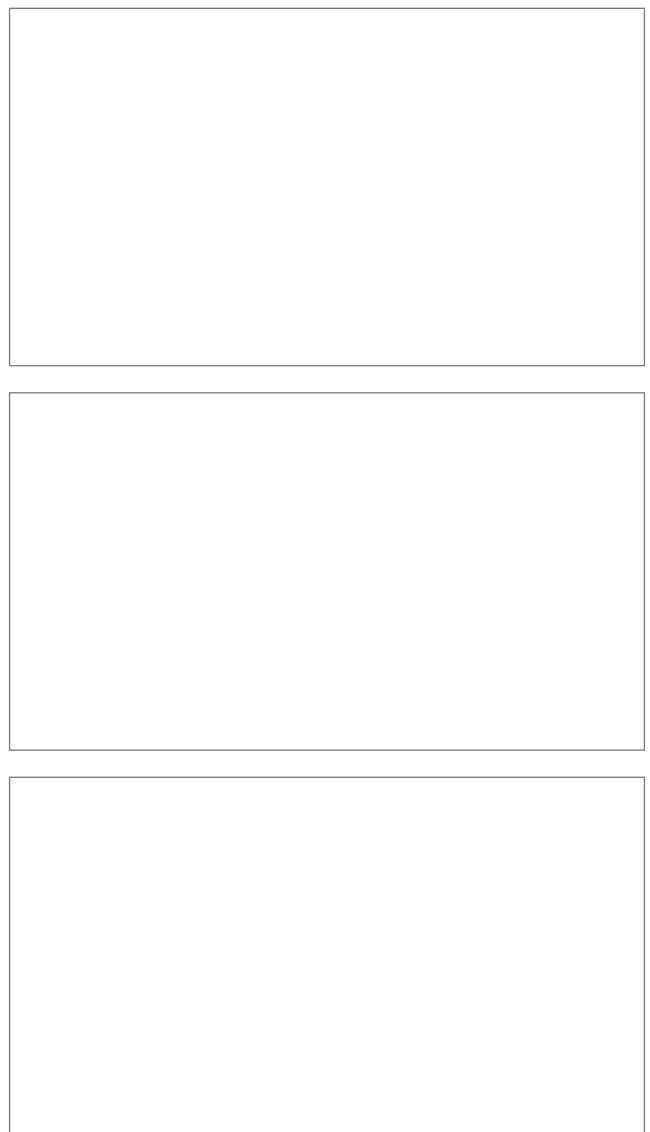
STEP 10

Time: 10 min

You now have all the components to imagine what the future might look like. On your workbook, take 5 minutes to individually draw **three ideas of fictional future experiences** (e.g., products, services, interactions) that could exist in your 😊 or ☹️ assigned future. Use pictures, not words.

In the remaining 5 minutes, share your ideas with your partner.

Notes:



SO WHAT...

STEP 11

Time: 10 min

Discuss and describe on your worksheet the “so what” for the **Main Stakeholder** you identified in step 2.

1. What abilities and/or resources would the Main Stakeholder need to **accelerate the** 😊 future? _____

2. What abilities and/or resources would the Main Stakeholder need to **prevent the** ☹ future? _____

3. What does the Main Stakeholder need to **watch out for** to know which future is unfolding? _____

4. What does the Main Stakeholder need to **do tomorrow to prepare** for the unknown future? _____

LET'S ALL BE FUTURISTS

You now have the basic skills to become a futurist. Here are some takeaway questions to ponder:

- In your community of practice (organization, city, volunteer, etc.) who do you **need to involve** in this exercise?
- What can you glean from the **other scenarios** that you did not explore today?
- How would all the other **stakeholder groups** influence your success in the future?
- What **values** today do you think would be the most difficult to change?
- What would it take to **test** one of your ideas in real life?

SPARKS GROVE FUTURES

www.sparksgrove.com

futures@sparksgrove.com

 **SPARKSGROVE**
NORTH HIGHLAND